Temporary & Situational Disabilities

Abi Harrison-Nye

What is it for?

Accessibility is often associated with permanent disabilities. But disability exists on a much wider spectrum.

A temporary disability will go away over time, like a broken arm or an eye infection that makes screens painful to look at.

A situational disability occurs when your environment creates the same barriers as a disability. For example, reading a phone in bright sunlight, or following audio in a loud pub.

How to support it

- Designers can ask, 'what if someone is doing this in harsh sunlight?' when checking colour contrast
- Developers can add captions to all video content
- Product Managers can include situational scenarios in user stories, like 'a user completing this task while commuting'

Designing for someone holding a baby also means designing for someone with a broken arm, and for someone with a permanent upper limb disability. One solution, three problems solved.

Useful Links

Microsoft Inclusive Design: Recognizing Exclusion

W3C: Diverse Abilities and Barriers